

Art Nouveau

An influential art and design movement that emerged in the final decades of the 19th century and ended with the First World War, Art Nouveau developed across Europe and America in provincial towns as much as in capital cities. A conscious attempt to create a unique and modern form of expression that evoked the spirit of the age, it manifested in painting, illustration, sculpture, jewellery, metalwork, glass, ceramics, textiles, graphic design, furniture, architecture, costume and fashion.

Art Nouveau evolved directly from the Arts and Crafts movement, drawing on influences including Celtic art and design, the Gothic Revival, the Rococo, Aestheticism, Symbolism and Japonisme. Aiming to raise the status of craft and decorative arts to that of fine art, practitioners endeavoured to produce 'total works of art' or '*gesamtkunstwerk*', in which every aspect was coordinated. Artists, designers and architects also aimed to harmonize with the natural environment, using flowing forms, sinuous lines and asymmetry, conveying an impression of movement.



Beardsley, *The Climax*, 1893